

College Hunks Hauling Junk & Moving: The Eggman

‘Eggman’ was not his given name, obviously, but that’s what I’m going to refer to him as in this here Google document. On the outside he did not resemble an egg whatsoever—in fact, he was Serbian—but on the inside...on the inside, I just know there was some kind of egg shit going on—something smooth and not complex just rolling around when he’s walking, idling while he’s sitting, vibrating while nodding out against the truck window, etc. The egg-brained man was of average height and build. He was quiet, walked a little clunky, and seemed a bit hazy—dopey, one might say.

I did a lot of jobs with him, and we were able to make easy conversation through our appreciation for guitar players and rock music. He was particularly fond of the Chili Peppers. He told me he played some guitar, and on at least three separate occasions said that he’d been struggling to learn the “Hotel California” solo, but more specifically, the very first bend. I always told him that you have to bend higher than normal in order to reach the note because it’s a whole step and a half higher, not just a whole step. He would never respond.

What was especially cool about the Eggnog and our shared taste in music was that I could have the radio set to something like 95.5 or 97.5 to passively play rock music in the background while we sat in traffic. I also discovered 97.5 HD2, a secret spin-off channel directly next to it that you can only access by shifting down, never up. There were no advertisements, and it spun deep cuts from ‘70s rock-centric albums, which was cool until it got into some of the more experimental and niche hunky-dory stuff that I personally think sounds too goofy for the inside of a dump truck.

One time, Egg got peed on by a client’s dog, and I’m pretty sure I noticed it happening before he did.

One time, I was driving while it was getting dark out, meaning I was also rushing to get back to the office, and I didn’t see a speed bump, and Egg never wore his seatbelt. I hit it at full speed, and he levitated completely out of his seat with his body still in a bent seating position for a whole 1 second. His arms flew

from his bottom ribs to shoulder height in one smooth wing-flap motion. I have a perfect snapshot captured in my brain, and if I think about it long enough, I'll laugh because the whole thing was so quiet; there was some banging from the truck's suspension and the sound of his keys in his pants jiggling as he ascended and landed, but that's it. He hit his head on the ceiling, I think, but he was fine. He then put on his seatbelt while I apologized profusely.

One time, Eggboy and I were sent to do a job at a house in an impoverished neighborhood. Two men were clearing out a house, and we were there to take the last of what was left. They helped us get the front door off its hinges so we could fit appliances through the doorway. This house had a narrow and crooked path of wooden steps to get to the front door, with 2 or 3 different turns in its journey from start to finish. Alongside it was a mechanical lift for anyone disabled. The platform was small, smaller than an average elevator platform, and with only enough space to hold one person. It was more square than it was rectangular and featured a set of buttons welded to the metal railings. When operated, the lift would take said user on the platform up to the level of the wooden walkway and allow the user onto it and enter the house from there.

At this job, we hauled one or two small items and some kitchen appliances. Egg and I managed to carry an old oven outside, down the staircase, and into the truck. The last and final requirement of the job was to take a refrigerator. I'm here to inform you that refrigerators leak water or some kind of liquid when you tip them over. The liquid is discolored and especially gross when it's been sitting there for god knows how many years.

Egg and I took turns swapping places throughout the whole ordeal, but what basically happened next was we were gonna try and roll the dolly with the refrigerator on it down the stairs one step at a time, but that strategy became less ideal when the turns on the way down the steps were too narrow. So, we put the fridge on the lift, and when we attempted to lower it and bring it down, it got stuck halfway. We actually broke the lift with it. The refrigerator that barely fit on the platform stood tall, and it was black, so it kind of looked like the monolith from *Space Odyssey*. It was still leaking. The monolith was pissing itself out of its fear of heights. We are sorry.

Cull dé sack Island House

One time, Eggboy and I drove to a job located in a cul-de-sac. But unlike your standard cul-de-sac house that lives on the perimeter facing in, it was instead built directly in the middle of this concrete oval—a very large, annoyingly flat, and distinctly modern-looking home. It looked like a rectangular, high-tech Rubik's Cube with hidden panels, sleek and wooden and office-like; modern and contemporary to the point that it's nauseating. Full-height windows perfectly square, and some of them memorably side by side. A box—a fancy, stupid box is what it looked like. The roof was one flat, black tile. The perimeter was gated with thin, metal bars that made the expensive home feel ironically reserved, like, 'Oh no, please, no one look at me,' while standing out in the middle of the cul-de-sac as what has to be the biggest eyesore for every neighbor.

Being in the center of everything, it lived like its own island, an oyster-shaped plot of lush land floating in a sea of asphalt, so separate from and surrounded by homes that were distinctly *not* modern that, with luck, would go for only half as much as this one on the market. It felt like a physical, wealthy insult to everybody.

Not only was this residence aesthetically misplaced, but it also kind of communicated the idea that whoever lives here is a real asshole. Wouldn't you feel like an asshole walking into your much nicer house on Asshole Island, away from and surrounded by all the other peasant houses? Actually, the answer is 'probably not' because only an asshole would buy this house in the first place.

I parked the truck off to the side of the street, calling the client with the College Hunks-provided work phone. We circled the house on foot at least twice, continuously spam-calling, and neither of us could find the entrance. Eventually a door opened like a hidden panel within a panel, lifeless and one-dimensional. We were greeted sternly by the client, an Asian woman in her 30s who was not in the best of moods. We struggled to find the gate to the concrete stairs leading up to it, and she made a verbal remark about our stupidity. Great start.

It felt dead inside. It was evening, like around 4:00pm or 4:30pm, the sun still out but on its way down, and for some reason there were no lights on, and the walls were a kind of dark blue, so for the next 40 minutes, everything had a blue tint to it, like looking through a highly saturated filter.

The interior was pristine and spacious with expensive minimalist furniture. The floor was hardwood and reflected with blur more than shine. The walls were monochrome and untouched. The woman wore a tank top and sweatpants. She was makeupless, and her face glistened from what had to be a large dose of some kind of moisturizer. I felt like it bothered her even more that we didn't (and couldn't) take off our disgusting work boots. She led us up to a small office space and gave us our task.

Simple: Take this quaint, white wooden table out of the office, down the stairs, out the front door, and into the dump truck. The problem was that it was just a few centimeters too wide to fit through the office doorway, so we had to take the legs off. The client was against this and, for some reason, adamantly asked us not to, so we tried again to carry it through the doorway, and in doing so, we made the smallest nick in the door. It was so tiny but so noticeable because of how spotless and newly coated the door was. It was my fault; I remember not being able to blame this on the Eggman in the back of my mind. I immediately had us put the table back before we accidentally caused any more damage. Luckily, the client didn't seem to notice the blemish.

We ever so delicately flipped the table on its top, more so to prevent any potential damage to the hardwood floor than to the table itself. After Eggnog here took his sweet fucking time to retrieve the toolbag from the truck, we began to deconstruct it, which, of course, was more time-consuming than it should have been; the accessibility for the Allen key was obscured by the table's aprons and corner brackets. Reaching the screw slots was tedious, and my struggling to do so seemed to annoy the already impatient client as she repeatedly checked in on us. Eventually, after like 20 minutes, we got the legs off and began taking the parts to the dump truck. The job was done, payment was received, and we left.

I drove us back to the office and went inside to drop off the keys, work phone, and card reader. I noticed Daddy J was a little sour. He immediately mentioned that we had to refund the last client because of a scratch on the door. He spun his never-not-plugged-in laptop 180° to show me a picture the lady uploaded, and Daddy J stressed that we be more careful next time.

(The Next Time)

Eggosaurus and I drove to a townhouse, one of many multi-family homes lined up side by side, each with some grass in between them. It was a nice little area; the trees made a natural ceiling out of green and provided shade.

We entered through a side door, greeted by a very polite mom whose 16- or 17-year-old son was sitting at the kitchen counter, hypnotized by a phone turned sideways in his bony hands. We followed her to the basement, where she showed us the sleeper couch that needed to be removed.

***Author's note: SLEEPERS SUCK. I HATE SLEEPER SOFAS. THEY ARE HEAVY. THEY ARE SO FUCKING HEAVY AND AWKWARD TO MOVE BECAUSE THE MATTRESS FOLDING MECHANISM WANTS TO KEEP OPENING AND IT FALLS OUT WHEN YOU'RE IN THE MIDDLE OF MANEUVERING THE DAMN THING.**

We agreed on a price, and she mentioned that she had somewhere to be and that she'll leave her credit card with her son, who will make the payment after the job is complete. I noticed she also left our tip with him as well: 2 generous \$20 bills.

Dude, fuck this thing. Their stairway was so compromising. It was narrow and had such a sharp turn. It was one of those L-shaped basement stairways that goes down one or two steps forward, then immediately takes 13 steps to the right all the way to the bottom. The wall held pictures in frames and a modern sconce for a light. It took me and Egg Sac at least 30 minutes to get this thing up the stairs. Going up was heavy but not the real problem; turning it and flipping it to get it out of the left-immediate doorway was almost impossible. Somewhere in the last 10 minutes, we really got to using our brains and did it somehow, but we scraped up the wall, and the sconce was loose and the portraits were crooked.

We brought it out of the same side door that we entered through, and either Eggroll or myself became too worn out to keep carrying it, so we dropped it to the concrete walkway and pushed until we got to the truck on the curb. This left 2 long, scraggly lines of faint brown all down the walkway.

I took payment from the kid and apologized about the crooked portraits and told him that the scuffs would come out no problem, even though I had no idea. He was quiet, but said not to worry about it. He gave us our tip, and we left.

Sometime later that day, on the way to another job, I get a call from sweet Daddy J. I say what's up and learn very quickly that Daddy J is upset :(He says we are forced to refund the client because we scuffed up the walls and the walkway outside. I told him I had absolutely no idea what he was talking about. He said the client was furious when she called. I said no-way-Daddy J and mentioned that we might've knocked into a picture frame, but that was really it. He argued that the pictures uploaded by the client showed otherwise, with a dent in the drywall as well as long streaks of what looked like actual shit along the walkway. I told him I didn't know anything about it.

College Spunk: Hort

One time, Daddy J sent me and my partner, Horton, way the hell out west. I drive us far and for at least 45 minutes. Somewhere within the last 10 minutes, we approach a railroad crossing. I notice the white work van in front of me in the right lane bounce dramatically over the crossing. I see this and pump the brakes before going over in the dump truck, and we heavily dip once or twice slowly. Considering how jolting it was going over it as slow as I did, it's evident that it would have been pretty rough had I not slowed down.

The midday sky is clear blue at its finest and portraitesque. Temperature's in the high 90s. Eventually, it doesn't feel like I'm anywhere near Chicago anymore, like any metropolis couldn't be further from me.

It begins to feel like truly nowhere when making the last couple of turns to the residence. We pull into a spread-out, middle- and working-class version of tract housing. It's got the quality of a silent thriller with a cookie-cutter layout, but the houses aren't exactly copied and pasted; they are spread out from each other with nothing but healthy, green earth in between them, with the occasional tree plotted here and there. This neighborhood is just 1-story houses nearby each other, affiliated only by road. The most accurate reference I can give is the neighborhood in *Edward Scissorhands*, and if you haven't seen that movie, what the fuck are you doing?

A horizon with no city in this heat makes the original world in which I'm living shrink without trace of a vacuum, and it becomes everything, as in, physically all there is.

This is all my world is.

And it's beautiful because it's not what you thought bliss would be like if you found it, but it is; it's like you understand it and experience it rather than cling on to some euphoric feeling. It's dreamlike in that it feels like the sun is fixed or time is frozen, and it's always daytime, no light ever dimmed by a speck. And it's calm, detached from all the bullshit. It's quiescent. Its palette is written in; no other colors exist besides what you see here. No one and nothing else exists besides me and what is here.

It feels like you're inside an Edward Hopper painting or the Windows XP default background—I'm not done here, this is a one of a kind feeling that I'm

talking about, and nearly impossible to describe, let alone recreate, and now is my chance—Think: if you were under the brightest sun and in the driest heat and behind the back of a mall outlet, behind the stores and looking up at the mono-colored walling, and you walk and walk and you just see more and more of this ancient yet pristine, muted pink wall with paint over the pipes and lumps until you finally come to the back corner, where you turn and then turn once more to find the storefronts, and you inspect them and quickly learn that they are all empty. Royally deserted. Untouched and not dusty or dirty. Not abandoned but never owned. Never a foot set inside. No products or signs or personality, just dull gondola shelving. No light switches, no technology to be realized, not even a circuit breaker; nothing to relate to, no one inside, nothing but the vagueness of the outer pink skins of the outlets themselves, its existence permanently ambiguous. You hear your footsteps and a distant wind, if anything at all. The parking lot is deserted, and the white paint on the asphalt dividing the parking spots appears as new as ever. No shadows at all or any silhouettes with dimensions relative to the sunlight—even in ways that are impossible. Not a fiber of trash and no trash cans. The parking lot doesn't even lead to a road; it's just a giant two-acre square. There is nothing farther, only grass, clean and surreal, but not at all fake grass, with each blade the exact same height, and beyond that is just more sky. The world is not round, nor is it flat; it just *is*. If you tried to run away from this skeletal shopping center, the distance you put between it and yourself would be real and would recede accordingly, but fantastically and inevitably, you come across the deserted shopping outlet again, and you come across it an infinite number of times over no matter where you run because the rest of the world has, in a morbid kind of way, been deleted, and this is all there is—a limited, limitless matrix; it just repeats itself once the replicated outlet and parking lot you run from are, once again, far enough behind you. What is absent hasn't even been deleted; it's never existed, because you, yourself, are incapable of considering literally that and otherwise; you're incapable of pondering if this is a dollhouse scenario or Something Greater's sandbox experiment, subject: you.

You don't get hungry, and you constantly sweat, but not exhaustingly, just the strange perfect balance between sweat-inducing heat and uncomfortably sticky cold post-sweat. It sounds like hell: a bright, clean, polished mask of what is really the most isolating realm of all. But with no other realms to compare it to, not even hypothetically, enter bliss.

It is a must that I type all of this out so that I can immerse myself and get back even just a sliver of the feeling because I yearn for it. It's the stuff of dreams and dreamscaped dreamlands.

Anyway, the violent ball in the sky is beaming and pounding, making me sweat endlessly. Every time I try to wipe my face with the front lower half of my drenched Elastereel College Hunks shirt, I inevitably apply more sweat to my face and spread it around, even. My cargo shorts are heavy on the outside with two encased iPhones, a card reader, a wallet, a vape, two sets of keys, and some loose change.

We enter this guy's house; he needs shit gone, we give him the price, he doesn't like it, we negotiate tediously for a while, and he gives in and we take the furniture. I'm pretty sure someone who lived here just died. I mean, you know I'd like to not charge the guy so much, but it literally fills up the entire truck. That's \$800.00 USD, and my partner and I only get 9% commission (in this case, \$72.00 USD).

We pack the truck to the brim, the client pays, and we head out.

I'm drenched, gross, and thirsty. I'm careful when making turns with this loaded dump truck. Deep down, I'm bummed to be exiting this private world with its supreme, dreamlike aura and going back to a noisy city.

Then, I see the railroad crossing up ahead. My beloved synapses fire, and my brain spits brilliance. I declare, out loud, slowly, "I can't *wait* to fucking hit this," and floor it. I squeeze my shoulder blades together and tighten my core muscles. I raise my cheeks and clench my jaw, squinting.

A sequence of three nightmarish booms takes over gravity; each individual slam against the ground is more aggressive than the last. It's uncomfortable, caught-off-guard; it feels like chomping with malocclusion, and it makes your head rattle. The passenger-side sun visor flies open, and stored company documents overhead break loose and slap at my coworker, who's coddling his Chipotle as rice leaps out of his now contorted aluminum bowl. The truck's frame clatters, and I'm certain we caught air. I look in my big side mirror and watch things fall out of the open truck bed and crack apart on the asphalt, just a couple, I think. My shoulders are higher than my head, my eyes still on the road; I come up from ducking as the truck stays strong and continues to drive smoothly. I look at my coworker, who is

covered in sheets of paper and rice. He looks at me seriously and says, “I can’t believe you just did that.”

One time, there was an old and disgusting second-floor apartment with furniture that looked sort of—not to sound dramatic—radioactive. Really, it was tarnished. The place was kind of yellow—the way The Backrooms are yellow. There was only the natural light coming through the windows, which were unusually blurred in a smoky, tan film. Anything or anyone on the other side is nothing short of totally indistinguishable. The oven and fridge were hardly intact: rusted, broken, stained, abandoned pieces of junk. Even the client remained in a car parked on the opposite side of the street the entire time and refused to go in with us.

Horty and I were pretty against this job. My concern was the possibility of bed bugs; Horty, on the other hand, I think, was just really grossed out. After surveying the place, he looked like he was about to cry. He called Daddy J while his lip and nostrils flared from disgust. He begged him to let us bail on this job.

“College Hunks has never turned down a job,” moans Daddy J.

Really? Ever? How do you know? Does it say so on your laptop?

Daddy loves to beg; he begs like this, like desperately, like *he’s* the one who’s gonna cry if we don’t do this: “Guys, please...” x10 and with devastating sighs in between.

I sent him pictures of what I wasn’t sure were bed bugs or not. I was looking up pictures of them on my phone to compare with what I was seeing. I couldn’t really tell. Of course, Daddy isn’t fazed; I mean, he’s *the* guy to see about bed bugs and bed bug infestations. He has a degree—a master’s degree, actually—in pest control from the University of Bed Bug Distinguishers (UBBD). I should have known he’d approve.

Horty was desperately bargaining to take only a few of the items, like boxes, a microwave, lamps, side tables, and a coffee table, etc., and it kind of worked.

Horty didn’t cry, and I didn’t get bed bugs—I guess that’s all that really matters.

One time, we went to this really nice 3-story townhouse. A 40-, 45-year-old Black gentleman and his 30-year-old-looking yoga-instructor-fit-level girlfriend

lived here—actually, the vibe was more like he’s the only one living here and she’s like, here for the day or night or something, I don’t know.

The man was pleasant, very welcoming. He stopped us before wandering any more than two or three steps into the house to have us put on reusable shoe covers, which was a great call, since our boots smell like decomposing fish and bad breath from unloading at the dump—let me explain something really quick: when the truck gets full and we go to “donate” the junk we’ve hauled, we visit waste management and contribute to the endless mountains of trash and all things discarded. We have to get out to open the back doors, which means planting our boots in a half-inch-deep layer of mucky-grime-slush matter. Gross? Yeah, but the stench...the stench is something *else*, let me tell you. It’s like, this whole time, any time you’ve ever taken in the smell of garbage, it’s like that was only *half* of the entire smell; you just never knew it. Let me say that the stench you have experienced is totally valid—it’s just that the waste management dump is a surprisingly *massive* upgrade from that, and you just don’t know until you know, you know?

All the time on television you see people vomiting in T-minus 3 seconds post-exposure to the stench of a dead human—even forensic scientists on CSI are scripted to lose it sometimes. I’ll be honest: I want to know what the fuss is all about. I’m a big boy; I can take on a good puking—I wanna know about this *instant* business. It feels gatekept, or like it’s some forbidden odor. I’m sure part of the inducing sickness is in combination with the sight of said rotting corpse, but still. I’ve never puked in an instant from purely just an odor, and I just want to know, that’s all. And I kind of want to know what my body will smell like when my soul’s gone and the lights are out.

Anyway, the man spoke more evenly than I’ve ever heard anyone speak. He walked with only his legs, which I know sounds like, *duh, no shit he walked with his legs*, but I mean his frame and his arms and especially his neck and head were completely still at all times. It seemed like he had a limited amount of muscles that he could use to make facial expressions, and said expressions seemed to come with some sort of latency.

He told us about his time spent in the Marines, which made his (what I perceived as) odd demeanor make sense. It also saddened me. I knew he wasn’t always like this.

The guy showed us around, though he didn't have us take anything from inside the house. He just had us rake leaves on concrete and then grab them by the handful and toss them into the back of the truck for maybe 25 minutes. I don't know; it was a little weird. He was adamant about each and every leaf being removed, so it took a while. He needs a leaf blower.

Harold Leroy

Harold Leroy. Goes by Leroy, but depending on the customer, he tactfully introduces himself as Harold. Mid- to late-20s Black man with dreads; almost always in a black muscle tee. Absolutely amazing partner to have for carrying heavy and awkward-shaped things; dogshit coworker and messy temper. Also, very horny.

One time, while ascending through the levels of a high-rise apartment building in a lavish elevator, our streamline to the designated floor was interrupted by a woman, likely in her mid-50s, blonde and kind of small; she got on with us, and Leroy greeted her respectfully. She responded with a brief smile and possibly a nod, then looked straight ahead at the closed doors until getting off at another floor that, again, was not ours. As she left, Leroy told her to have a good one, and she smiled and waved on her way out. The doors shut, and Leroy looked at me and said, “Yo, I think she’s into us.”

One time, “Young Lust” by Pink Floyd was ending on the radio, which features the quiet words of a British phone operator whose caller keeps getting disconnected, causing dispatcher sounds and a loop of the recurring beeps that are heard when there’s no connection in 1970s England. Leroy flipped out at this. He asked me what the fuck that was. I told him it’s part of the recording. He put his ear to the center console and looked up at me with his fully opened bloodshot eyes and asked desperately, “THE POLICE?!”

One time, he left the toolbag and drill behind at a job in the morning, which had one hell of a ripple effect on the rest of the day.

One time—actually, many times—he would comment on women’s figures, usually breasts or tush, then ask me if I got a look at her ass, to which I would reply no because I’m driving, and he would then unpromptedly describe her and, more particularly, her butt, to me as best he could. Many times, he would roll down the window and catcall. As much as I wanted to tell him to knock it off, it was just

really out of the question with this guy. Just thinking about *trying* to stop him seemed ridiculous.

One time, though, while at a stoplight in the middle of downtown, he pointed out a woman strolling along the crosswalk. Since we weren't just passing her in less than 2 seconds, he had time to really get a good look at her, and his mind began playing out fantasies in real time—literally. He gave a status report on what he thought of her ass and face and then told me to quote, “Imagine that she’s sucking your dick right here while I play with her ass,” unquote, and used his hands to clearly dictate how and where her hypothetical body would be in reference to the two of us in this confined dump truck cab, as well as what his hands would be doing *to* her.

I just looked at him. He was so serious. It’s extremely rare that I become genuinely speechless. What the fuck do you even say to that? Should I have been like, “Hell yeah, dude, good call—up top!”? Should I have contributed? Like, “Ooh, yeah, and then imagine I start making pig noises, not blinking while I look at you!”?

Or should I have said what I really felt, which was that I never thought I’d be placed in another man’s verbal sex fantasy *unironically* and in real time like that, and that I hope it never happens again—ever.

One time, we almost got into a real scrap, which truly would have been a tragedy because he is very jacked and my face is gorgeous. It was me, him, and Eggboy on a junk job. It was windy and a little chilly outside. Leroy, in his tank top, asked me why I was wearing a windbreaker. I told him. He said, “But you’re sweating.” I said, “That’s because I’ve been hauling boxes up and down stairs for 10 minutes.” He said, “Yeah, you tryna keep them lil nuts warm.” I asked, “Why are you worried about my nuts?” and he got in my face, and I had to diffuse the damn thing, while Eggdick stumbled around the job in his post-heroin-use-like stupor. God forbid I wear a fucking windbreaker in the city of Chicago.

One time, he switched the radio to trap music and cranked it. After a minute, I turned it down, as in, I lowered the volume, not shut it off. I just brought it down—not even ‘down,’ I just took it from being all the way up to like halfway, which resulted in a look of madness beaming at me from the passenger seat. A

screaming match ensued until he had me drop him off at a random street on the way back to the office.

Uncle T

Uncle T. Or, UT, if you want—a 64-year-old Black gentleman, active as a motherfucker, could no doubt climb a fence quicker than I could any day. He has no teeth—literally, just gums—but he’s easy to understand. He’s also not my uncle, for the record.

On multiple occasions, I heard him state that he’s retired. I asked why he does this job, and he gave a pretty sensible reason: He doesn’t want to sit around and become decrepit.

Fun fact: he did 10 years for murder. I know this because one time, when on a junk removal, there was no way of getting this big metal bedframe down the stairs and out to the truck. The only other option was to get it through the doorway to the outside deck, but it still didn’t really look like we’d make it through, so I suggested that we just disassemble it. He cut me off, standing on the other side of the frame, and said, “I killed a guy.” I asked, “What?” and then he said, “What?”

There were other instances where he would bring it up. He said it to a customer who was rushing us to take apart some furniture. The customer said something along the lines of “Hey, do you guys mind hurrying up?” and Uncle T was not about that.

He said, “*Hell* naw, man.”

The customer being on the phone at the same time didn’t help any.

“Don’t talk to me like I’m a motherfucking child, bro.”

UT said that maybe 4 or 5 times within the span of 20 seconds. In between one of those times, however, he added, “I did 10 years.”

Fun fact: If the dollies are not secured or lying on their tops in the back of the truck, they slam against the truck wall any time you hit the brakes. All that is to say, one time, Uncle T got real mad at me because it startled the shit out of him when I hit the brakes hard.

One time, we had to take a moldy mattress out of someone’s basement apartment, which had recently flooded. It was like a boiler room and grossly tan. The mattress itself was soaked, which made it ten times heavier. The mold made it look bruised—bruised the way old people’s bruises look bruised—purple, harsh,

concerning. On the way out of that place only a roach would call an apartment, the mattress leaked and pissed itself. I think it was scared. We were taking it away from its safe space. It had already been, I guess, in a way, waterboarded or damn near drowned by the flooding, then beaten and bruised horribly from the disgusting mold, and now we were carrying it out sideways. Let it piss; it deserves the freedom to. Poor thing.

Honorable Mentions

First of all, Lower Wacker can suck my nuts. The GPS gets all fucked, and so do I. PSA: Never go down there if you don't have to, and God bless you if you do.

One time, when we didn't have any jobs scheduled and had serious time to kill, Daddy J had us go advertise. He made sure our dump truck was well-stocked with College Hunks yard signs for us to distribute around Chicago. My partner for the day, Pat, joined me for this bullshit task.

Here's the deal: Daddy J told us to drive around and distribute all of what was stowed in the truck, which was something like 80. He told us to distribute all of them. He didn't say distribute *some* from A to B or around A and/or around B; he said get rid of all of them since we had so many piling up in the office—but see, that's where he fucked up.

Pat and I went out trying to get rid of these things as fast as we could. Imagine getting a dump truck, pulling over, and stopping at least 40 different times to get out and put a sign in a patch of grass on either side of a road with 4 lanes of city traffic. Fuck that. We did maybe 15–20 stops and just walked a bit while placing as many as we could. Pat was actually planting them in twos, side by side, at one point. In less than an hour, all of the signs were successfully distributed within a 3-mile span, all down Addison.

We sat in a gas station parking lot, eating while waiting for the next job to come up, if at all. An hour later, the work group chat blew up. As usual, Daddy J was unhappy.

“Whoever littered Addison with yard signs needs to go retrieve them ASAP, or we will get fined.”

Someone put an “lol” in response to it, and Daddy J, who, like I said, was *not* happy, responded, “Not funny”—which gave me the urge to immediately send an all-caps “LMAO.”

He added, “We will get fined \$500/day until it's cleaned up.”

‘We’?

Who's ‘we’?

As in *me* with *you*?

Like, *I'm* gonna get fined? Whatever—didn't matter. I had to go and undo my lazy little job.

Also yes, the montage of scattered yard signs on our way to retrieve them was a ridiculous sight. If you were looking at one, it was impossible not to see another one in your peripheral. But what is the exact distance in which these are allowed to exist without a fine? And according to whom, exactly? And who's measuring if it appears that they're too close together? Plus but what if they really aren't? Whatever. When I got back to the office, I told Daddy J I hope he's happy. He said, "I'm not happy. I'm divorced."

One time, when we came back to the office, or as Daddy J called it, 'HQ,' which, to this day, I have not gotten over how ridiculous that sounds, a noticeably intoxicated Chuck offered us Coronas on the lot. He was unusually out of uniform, and when I asked him about it, he said he wasn't on the clock and was actually just about to go pick up his son. He finished his beer with a swig. Author's note: I don't like to do jobs with Chuck because, in my opinion, he's too nice about the quotes we give the customers, and he also barks at women he finds attractive from inside the truck, and he does like a little dog bark, not like a hound dog or a big dog. It's more of a chihuahua yap, and he's kind of shy with it, so I'm the only one who ever hears it, which I suppose is better than the alternative.

One time, upon entering a 30-something-year-old's 2nd-floor apartment, I saw goat heads and goat-headed statues attached to the body of a man featuring more than just 2 arms and other things that I would consider suspicious. To each their own, I guess.

One time, I had to do a full day of jobs with this old dickhead who would litter while I was driving and chain-smoke Newports with his window up. He would drop racial slurs like nobody's business. He had few teeth thanks to someone smashing him in the mouth with a baseball bat when he was an Uber driver shortly before working at College Hunks. His ride was stolen too.

My real irritation with him, though, is actually because he would grunt *every* time he lifted something. Even if it wasn't that heavy, he would make a noise. He never actually struggled; he was fine, but he'd pick up a wooden dining chair and make the same breath-grunt-strain as someone doing a deadlift. Pissed me off.

College Spunks: The Final Spunk

My final day as a College Hunk was unforeseen. I shared this shift with my good man, Horthy, on a sunny July day in downtown Chicago, the Gold Coast, right on the edge of North Lake Shore Drive. The client's out of town, so Daddy J relays the job details to us. 1325 N Astor Street, Unit 13.

We park the dump truck right outside the building's entrance. The jobsite is a large, luxurious condo on the 13th floor. The lobby feels ingenuinely wealthy, especially when turning the corner through a thin and dark hallway to the freight elevator that is no bigger than a bathroom stall. It's shabby and worn—fully functional, but comparing it to the lobby's pseudo-elegance makes it surprisingly cramped and dirty.

After reaching the designated floor, we walk out and enter another elevator down the hall. This time, the interior is looking more refined, and it takes us directly into the condo itself. The residence occupies the entire floor and has an additional level of its own, accessible via marble spiral staircase.

I step out of the elevator like Dorothy into Oz, immediately gazing at the surprising height of the ceilings and the wall's masking arches. The ring-shaped vestibule is floored with non-reflective marble; its center one giant medallion inlay. Hanging from a hole in the ceiling above is a chandelier that holds more diamonds than it does light bulbs.

6 bedrooms, 6 full bathrooms, 7900 sq feet, and an estimated retail value of \$2.3 million. Huge and empty. Totally unfurnished besides a few tables and a laptop on a desk that I learned very quickly to be plastic and not at all real. It opened up and had a giant sticker pretending to be the screen with a cursor and desktop icons and everything. All of the rooms are connected with round arched walkways and halls; only the bathrooms and bedrooms have doors. The wainscoted walls maintain a fawn brown with marble trim. Various shades and patterns of parquet hardwood and slick tiling alternate on a room-to-room basis.

High ceilings. Ornate and dentil crown molding. The walls curve with chess piece-like smoothness. Door panels are intricately carved and molded expensively. So much of the wall's surface area is molded; some of them look like giant cabinets. In a dining room, a never-ending floral pattern is faint on every wall. There are more vines and tendrils and leaves than flowers or buds.

All is illuminated by natural light via 15 ft. tall arched windows, lengthy picture windows, tall single-hung windows, and 10 ft. high double-hung windows recessed over 2 feet deep with 12 cut-ups.

An isometric mirror built into the wall above 1 of 4 wood-burning fireplaces is itself with 36 barely visible cuts.

As unsurprising as this sounds, the kitchen is doing a little too much. Everything needed to do regular kitchen shit is against one really long wall + an island countertop featuring 6 drawers and a mini fridge inside of it. Opposite this wall of counters/stove, etc., is an array of floor-to-ceiling decorative shelving behind glass cabinet doors. Its whole configuration is bowed, so it's out of the way physically, but it's not casual and it's not pretentious; it's a word that I can't seem to find—basically, a cross between lavish and immodest—but it's the enormous shelving that is immodest, not the hypothetical homeowner. The thing isn't even grandiose or making itself out to be a big deal, i.e., no one shelf is bigger or more center or more anything than another—it's just kind of massive altogether and too much all at once, in a way.

The stove is kind of built into the counter the way a sink typically is. Attached to it are two horizontal rods made out of bronze—I think. They can easily pass for handles, which makes me think they open up for grilling or some other crazy shit. Above it, of course, is a massive range hood.

Besides the outrageous amount of cabinets built into and above the counters, there is a stainless steel double sink and, eventually, a massive refrigerator. It's vault-like—but not a typical bank vault cog-looking thing—it's a giant panel of stainless steel with a modernistic handle vertically attached on the far left. It looks like you would need both hands and good core strength to open it by yourself.

But a little bit further and through a doorless doorframe is a wet bar, which features another full-size fridge, another sink (this time, single), and an oven.

Hanging above one of the other fireplaces is a large piece of abstract wall art that makes me think of *Among Us*.

Up the spiral staircase and into a circular room above the vestibule are more arched doorways. The 1st floor's chandelier canopy is rooted at the height of this 2nd floor room's ceiling and is attached by an extensive black chain through the circular gap in the middle of the carpeted floor. Its perimeter is guarded by black

iron railing akin to a fire poker and with thin balusters whose design briefly swells midway, creating inverted teardrop-shaped holes.

One of the passages leads to an exercise room. Two single-hung windows with 4 cut-ups side by side on the outer wall; the other opposing walls are nothing but full-sized mirrors. One end has a small TV hanging from the ceiling.

There are four balconies, one per corner of the condo's first level, each accessible via 2 pairs of double doors with transom lights and black steel frames and mullions. There's enough room to fit a grill and seat 3–5 people at a table comfortably. They are roofless, with all stone-tiled flooring, high as actual fuck, and housing at least one large rectangular planter against the stone railing.

Originally black, the planters are deteriorated, rusting heavily, and made of solid metal. Some of them have literal piles of rust inside, rotten-looking Fruity Pebble flakes of orange heaped into the far ends. They are something like 10 feet wide, maybe 3.5 feet tall, and 2 feet deep. They are practically unliftable, even for a few steps, and any feasible grip on the inner edges risks cutting and getting tetanus. We call up Daddy J and he confirms that the planters are to be removed.

We argue with him about the job, explaining why it's impossible with only two people + the weight + the risk of damaging something on the way to the first elevator and maneuvering it to even fit, then taking it out and over to elevator #2 and doing exactly that again, which seems even more impossible because of how much smaller elevator #2 is, and then through the narrow passages and out to the dump truck—not happening.

Besides the elevator obstacles, it's not that this job can't be done, but it certainly is not going to be possible for me. This job requires what the job title actually reps: a hunk—actually, *hunks*, plural. We are adamant that this isn't a two-man job, and Daddy J says he'll call back to let us know if anyone can come in to help us. We wait and complain to each other until Daddy J calls to tell us no one's available for the moment.

I tell Daddy that I won't do it. My boy is no more happy about the situation than I am, but if anyone is more capable physically, it's him. Daddy gets mad. My boy diffuses the situation and tells him that we'll look for another way. Once off the phone with a now grumpy Daddy J, I tell my boy that I can't do this job physically and that I am sorry. Regarding my decision to walk off the job or stay, he takes a neutral stance. I tell him that I won't walk off if it means that it would

leave him solely responsible for this clusterfuck, but he insists that it won't and that he'll be fine.

At this point, I'm working at Hub 51, and my schedule for College Hunks has diminished to only Mondays. Daddy J has recently said that he continues to pair me up with my boy because we've been racking up sales and "making him a lot of money," which is great because I could look forward to it since I knew I would have laughs with my friend (and in case you haven't heard, most of the other coworkers are insufferable). I call Daddy J and I tell him that I'm not doing it. He gets really upset, more so saddened, but he switches over to being angry here and there, too. Like I've heard him say before, "College Hunks has never turned down a job—ever." Well, I don't know what to say because that statement doesn't make me feel anything. It's not like this is *his* company. I have the urge to say "So?" but I know that spiritually, my goal isn't to be a smartass or win an argument right now—I'm trying to grapple with the fact that I'm not going to do something that I said I would. I am conditioned to consider the idea that I am disappointing to the external world for committing such a crime and can tell you that, while it doesn't mean it's true, it does for me in this moment, because after I hand the phone back to my boy, and he argues neutrally on the line, he whispers, "Daddy J called you a 'fucking pussy.'"

I did, indeed, pussy out—but I wouldn't call it "fucking" pussying out—I just couldn't do it physically. I had to say fuck it. Before I leave, I dap up my dear brother and wish him luck in school and with Daddy J. It was fun while it lasted, most of the time.

About a month and a half later, I'm really missing the burning light and stinging sweat in my eyes while tearing my body's muscles and making money with my coworker who became a friend. Those were good times. But I could have easily overstayed and resented the job; winter would come and surely be burdensome, my boy would be back at school in Michigan, and I wouldn't be having fun working with the other psychopaths. Sometimes I catch a vibe and still miss it, just those good parts, and for only a moment. But what's ultimately perfect is that those days happened, and I enjoyed them. I'm grateful that I get to remember them... Or, at least, that's what I tell myself so that I don't yearn so hard.

Alexa, play "Boys of Summer" by Don Henley.

Closing

If you made it this far, I'd like to thank you for listening or reading. I have no real reason to write this stuff and record me saying it. I guess you could call this 'art.' The only thing I really hope for anyone after engaging with this is any type of positive emotion or feeling. I know I'm not the only person who thinks and feels the way I do, but sometimes I do feel alone, and so if you feel that way or whatever way, I hope this helped. Thanks again, and goodbye.